

2 Peter: A Translation and Commentary

Stephen L. Brown

Version 1.0

Zongse Publishing

© 2025

This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>). You are permitted to print, electronically redistribute, translate, incorporate into larger works, and/or to include this work in larger print or electronic platforms. It is requested that authorial attribution is maintained and that any additions to, subtraction from, or comments on the present work are clearly indicated to be the work of another author or editor.

Dedicated to Stevie and Kimmy Parris, with son Ender

Preface

This document contains a literal translation of the book of 2 Peter, followed by a verse-by-verse commentary. Brackets indicate words not found in the original but added for clarity. I have also written a commentary on 1 Peter, which will be referenced at times in this commentary.

May God's grace give growth and true knowledge to his people as they await Jesus' return.

1:1 Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ, to those who have received a faith just as precious as ours by the righteousness of our God and Savior, Jesus Christ. **2** Grace to you, and peace be multiplied in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord!

1:3 [I greet you this way] because his divine power has given us what is conducive to life and piety through the knowledge of him who called us by [a display of] glory and excellence, **4** through which his precious and great promises have been given to us, so that through these we might become participants in the divine nature, having escaped the earthly corruption that consists in lust. **5** And for this very reason, exhibiting full diligence, supply for your faith excellence, for your excellence knowledge, **6** for your knowledge self-control, for your self-control endurance, for your endurance piety, **7** for your piety brotherly affection, for your brotherly affection love. **8** For when these [virtues] are yours and are increasing, they make you neither useless nor unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. **9** By the same token, the person who lacks these [virtues] is blind and shortsighted, having forgotten the cleansing of his former sins. **10** Therefore all the more, brothers and sisters, be diligent to establish surety in your calling and election; for in implementing these things you will absolutely never stumble. **11** For thus entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ will be abundantly supplied to you.

1:12 Therefore, at no time will I be unprepared to remind you about these things—even as you know and have been established in the truth which is present with you. **13** But I consider it right, for as long as I am[, so to speak,] in this tent, to prod your memory, **14** knowing that the removal of this tent is near (just as indeed our Lord Jesus Christ has indicated to me); **15** at any rate, I will be diligent to keep your memory fresh on every occasion that presents itself until my departure.

1:16 For we did not follow clever myths when we made known the power and presence of our Lord Jesus Christ. On the contrary, we were eyewitnesses of the gloriousness of that man: **17** having received from God honor and glory, a voice was borne to him from the majestic glory [of heaven's throne], "This is my beloved Son, with whom I myself am fully pleased." **18** And this voice from heaven we heard with our own ears when it came when we were with him on that holy mountain. **19** And we

have more sure the prophetic word—to which [prophetic word] you do well to hold onto as if it was a lamp shining in an abysmal place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts, **20** knowing this first of all: no prophecy is one's own prerogative; **21** on the contrary, holy men of God, carried by the Holy Spirit, spoke.

2:1 But there were indeed false prophets among the people, as among you also there will be false prophets, who provoke destructive factions, and who forsake the Sovereign who bought them, instigating for themselves sudden destruction. **2** And many follow them in their [example of] insolence; because of them the way of truth is libeled. **3a** They also traffic in deceitful, contrived tales.

2:3b Theirs is an ancient judgment that will not be idle, and their destruction will not sleep. **4** For if God did not spare the angels who sinned, but bound them with the chains of the darkness of Tartarus while they are kept for [the day of] judgment; **5** and [if] the ancient world he did not spare (but he protected a group of eight including Noah, a proclaimer of righteousness), striking the world of the ungodly with utter destruction; **6** and [if] the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah he decisively judged, reducing them to ashes, making them a foreshadowing the judgment about to come for the practice of ungodliness; **7** and [if] righteous Lot, who was being worn out by the conduct of unethical, insolent people—**8**what I mean is that that righteous man was being tortured in his righteous soul day after day as he dwelt with them by the lawless deeds he saw and heard—**9**[then] the Lord knows how to rescue the pious from testing, but to keep the unrighteous contained until the day of judgment, **10a** especially those who go after impure bodily desires or belittle authorities.

2:10b Bold, presumptuous, not trembling at glorious things, blaspheming. **11** Where[as] angels, though greater in strength and capacity, do not bring by themselves a railing condemnation [purported to be] from the Lord, **12** these people, like irrational animals, born to be captured and destroyed, blaspheme things they do not understand, in the midst of their destroying will be destroyed, **13** receiving the wages of their unrighteousness. Setting their minds on pleasure in the luxurious day, spots and blemishes in their deceptiveness as they feast together with you, **14** having eyes full of an adulteress and ceaseless in sin, baiting unsteady souls, having hearts trained in greed, [these are] people under a curse: **15** having forsaken the upright way, they have wandered, having followed the way of Balaam, son of Bosor, who loved the wages of unrighteousness, **16** and received reproof for his wickedness—a donkey, making sounds with a human voice, prevented the prophet's foolishness [from succeeding]. **17** These people are wells without water, clouds driven by stormwinds, for whom the deepest darkness is kept forever. **18** For uttering words of hybistic emptiness, they lure with licentious bodily desires those who in reality had escaped those who live deceitfully, **19** promising freedom to them, even as they themselves are slaves of corruption (whatever one surrenders to one is in fact a slave to): **20** if, having escaped the impurities of the world by the knowledge of the Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, these people, entangling themselves again, have been overcome, the end has become worse for them than the beginning. **21** After all, it would have been better for them not to have known the way of righteousness than, aware of it, to turn away from the holy commandment that was handed to them. **22** The proverb has come true in their case: "A dog returns to its own vomit"; and, "A pig after washing rolls in the mud."

3:1 This is now the second epistle I am writing to you, beloved, in which I am stirring up your sincere minds **2** to remember the words spoken beforehand by the holy prophets and your apostles by the command of the Lord and Savior, **3** knowing this first of all: in the last days deceivers will come with their own lust[ful dispositions] **4** and asking, "Where is the promise of his coming? After all, from the moment the fathers passed away, everything has continued as it has since the beginning of creation." **5** They say this because they willfully forget that the former heavens and earth were fashioned by the word of God out of water and through water, **6** through which [water] they were destroyed by a flood. **7** And the heavens and earth which presently exist by his word are [similarly] being kept for a fire reserved for the day of judgment and of the destruction of impious people. **8** But do not let this one thing be forgotten by you, beloved: with the Lord, one day as a millennium, and a millennium is as one day. **9** The

Lord is not slow to keep his promise (for some think it slow), but is patient with us, not desiring that anyone perish, but that everyone would accept repentance. **10** This day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night, and the earth and its works will be burned.

3:11 So then, with everything to be destroyed in this manner, what sort of people ought you to be, [living] with holy conduct and piety, **12** waiting eagerly for and hastening along the coming of the day of God, for the sake of whom the heavens will be burned and destroyed and the elements will be superheated and melt? **13** But we, in view of his promise, are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.

3:14 Therefore, beloved, while you wait for these things, be diligent to be found peacefully in him without spot or blemish, **15** and count our Lord's patience as salvation, just as our beloved brother Paul, according to the wisdom given to him has written to you, **16** as in all his epistles he speaks about these things. (These things contain certain difficult elements, which the foolish and unstable twist, as indeed [they twist] the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction. **17** You then, beloved, knowing these things beforehand, be on your guard, so that you might not be carried off with any lie of the impious and fall from your own stability, **18** but be growing in the grace and knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and into the day of eternity! Amen.

Notable Abbreviations

cf.: Compare, see also

e.g.: For example

esp. Especially

etc.: And so on, and the others

f(f): And the verse(s) following the one cited

lit.: literally

NKJV: New King James Version

NLT: New Living Translation

NT: New Testament

OG: Old Greek (otherwise known as the Septuagint), that is, one of principal the translations of the Hebrew Bible into Greek made in ancient times

OT: Old Testament

viz.: namely, that is.

1:1.1 *Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ*: Peter introduces himself in much the same way as he did in his first epistle. In a slight change, he adds his other (and original) name, Simon.¹ Often God's renaming of an individual does not mean that the prior name can no longer be used, only that the new name points to some new reality. So it is that Jesus, who gave Simon the name "Peter" (Jn 1:42,² reaffirmed in Mat 16:18), continues at various points to call him "Simon" (e.g., Mat 16:17, Jn 21:17).

The other change from his greeting in 1 Pet 1:1 is making explicit what was implicit before, viz. that he is a "servant." "Here Peter claims the highest authority that anyone could claim in the early church—that of being an Apostle. At the same time, like the Apostle Paul, he identifies himself as a slave. He is simultaneously the highest and the lowest of Christian society" (Sproul, 180).³

¹ I have regularized the spelling, since in English it is not the practice these days to have multiple spellings. In the Greek NT, Peter's Hebrew name is usually Σίμων but in Ac 15:14 and here Συμεων (possibly reflecting in part dialectical variation in the (non)realization of the schwa after the *mem* in the underlying Hebrew שמעון).

² Aramaic כִּפְּא ("Cephas") is the equivalent of Greek Πέτρος ("Peter").

³ In both ancient and modern times, and at certain points in between, the authorship and/or canonicity of 2 Peter has been much doubted in the Church. (These two issues are ultimately separable, but are closely related.) On the matter of canonicity, suffice it to say that while there has been more doubt about this book than perhaps any other

1:1.2 *to those who have received a faith just as precious as ours:* Peter is writing particularly to the churches in Anatolia: in 3:1 Peter says this is his second letter, connecting it to 1 Peter, written to that region.⁴ That said, God the Holy Spirit through this letter of Peter's produced holy Scripture, which is profitable for all saints (2 Tim 3:16-17) and a source of hope through Christ even for those who live long after its initial writing (Rom 15:4).

The word for "received" (λαγχάνω), one of a number of words that could have been chosen, is ennobling and empowering: it often carries a certain suggestion of having legally acquired property or have been duly appointed to some office (cf. Montanari, 1207a-b). It is not a mere accident that the Anatolian believers are Christians; they have been called to this, just as Peter often pointed out in his first epistle (1:1.3, 1:15.1, 2:9.1, etc.). And it is no small thing that they have received: it is something just as "precious" (or valuable; setting aside the comparative prefix used here, the word is the same as that in 1 Pet 1:19) as that of Peter and the other apostles. Surely implied here is the same amazement that Peter expressed in his first letter (1:8) that his readers, though lacking his own face-to-face experience with Jesus, nevertheless believe.

But what have the Anatolian believers received? The word "faith" here could refer (1) to the fact of each one's faith in Christ (e.g., Rom 5:1) or (2) the totality of Christianity (e.g., Jude 3). While Peter affirms that salvation comes from faith, not one's own effort (cf., e.g., 1 Pet 1:5.1, 1:21.2), probably the latter idea is what he has in mind here, since in the following verse he will use a continuative conjunction (ὡς) to launch into a wide-ranging discussion of Christianity and its associated virtues.

1:1.3 *by the righteousness of our God and Savior, Jesus Christ:* The basis for the Christian faith is the righteousness of God, not the righteousness of men and women. Christianity is not about people pulling themselves up by their bootstraps, but about a merciful God reaching down to take their hand.

This righteousness is specifically that of Jesus Christ, who is astonishingly not only holy God but gracious Savior. Now, in English the words "our God and Savior" could be read to mean "our God and also our Savior," but the Greek is unambiguous:⁵ Jesus is God, as well as Savior. And Peter adds the word "our": Jesus is these two astonishing things not only in reference to him, but also in reference to the believers in Anatolia, even those in Anatolia who have yet to see Jesus with their own eyes.

1:2 *Grace to you, and peace be multiplied in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord:* Peter repeats the greeting he used in his first epistle (1:2.5), but in an expanded form (adding "in the knowledge of God and of Jesus Christ our Lord"). This expanded greeting will be restated at the conclusion of the epistle (3:18.1), so that the combination of the grace of God with the knowledge of God forms the bookends of the letter.

NT book, even so it is a minority of voices within the Church that has questioned the book, and very few have rejected it outright. At least since the days of Athanasius, the book has had such a wide acceptance within the Church, despite the challenges around its authorship, that its place in the Church can be considered secure. On the matter of authorship, the book does indeed feel different in terms of style—and arguably in terms of approach—than 1 Peter. But we have only two brief books from this man (and, in this second book, about a third of it is seemingly a paraphrase of someone else's work—see below on 2:1-22.1) who in his long and eventful life would have been exposed to many people and many ideas. Some have proposed the use in one or both of his epistles of a secretary who did much of the actual writing and so is responsible in large measure for the style, but this can only be speculation (cf. on 1 Pet 5:12.1). It is legitimate to wonder why the style is so different, but overbold to claim that Peter could not have written this epistle. Do note the particularly Jewish way of speaking in 1:17 and the notable phraseology in 3:15 (on which see Davids, 298-299).

⁴ On this area, see the first footnote on 1 Pet 1:1.3.

⁵ See von Siebenthal §132c.

It is possible that in adding the word *knowledge* Peter intends to subvert a trendy but erroneous doctrine marketing some special “knowledge” (cf. 1 Tim 6:20). Knowledge worth having is not knowledge of deep mysteries, but the knowledge of God. Here there is some ambiguity as to whether the knowledge is of God the Father and also of God the Son, or knowledge of God who is Jesus. Of course, the difference is not great, since knowing Jesus is knowing the Father (Jn 14:8ff) But probably Jesus is particularly in view here, for it would seem to be his deeds that will shortly be celebrated (1:3.3).

1:3.1 [*I greet you this way*] *because his divine power has given us what is conducive to life and piety*: God has not been skimpy with his gifts, but rather has done something only he could do: he has supplied the Anatolians, no less than those who had once walked the land with Jesus, all knowledge necessary to live well. Clearly, everyone on the earth has life; the meaning of “life” here is “life lived well.”

“Piety” (εὐσεβία; see further on 1:6.3 below) refers to allowing one’s loyalty to God to drive the way one behaves. God does not supply all knowledge about everything (such as how to multiply large numbers without a calculator or to avoid all swindles in the marketplace), but he gives ample direction on the things that really matter.

1:3.2 *through the knowledge of him who called us*: God’s gifts are not ultimately separable from himself. To know how to live well is to know God personally (not merely to know about him). This interpersonal relationship did not start with Peter’s readers, but with God who summoned them (cf. 1 Peter 1:15.1).

There is some ambiguity as to whether it is the Father or the Son who calls here (see Schreiner, 291). In light of the following words, which I take as a reference to the work of Christ, Peter is evidently thinking of Jesus’ call here.

1:3.3 *with [a display of] glory and excellence*:⁶ Peter is picking up on Hellenistic terminology here, the combination of “glory” (δόξα) and “excellence” (ἀρετή) being a stock way of celebrating a man or woman whose public display(s) of valor have achieved lasting fame (Green, 183-184). And how brave Jesus was! In his humanity, he did not possess an impressive appearance, nor did he find himself surrounded by influential (or even, in his hour of greatest need, loyal) followers; he did not even have a home of his own as he spoke to endless masses of downtrodden, demon-possessed, disease-racked people, all the while having his every word and action scrutinized by hostile experts in the minutiae of law and tradition. And how great his achievement was! His life was the complete and sole encapsulation in a human being of obedience to the spirit of God’s holy law, and his death passed through the darkest valley imaginable and successfully secured eternal life in a righteous way for God’s wayward children.

1:4.1 *through which his precious and great promises have been given to us*: Christ’s “glory and excellence”—that is, as described above, his earthly life and his work upon the cross—has secured God’s promises for us. The OT overflows with promises for God’s children, promises that are wider and deeper than any human promise.

1:4.2 *so that through these we might become participants in the divine nature, having escaped the earthly corruption that consists in lust*: That is, through the outworking of God’s promises we might participate in God’s nature, having escaped the desirable things of this world that promise pleasure but deliver destruction.

There is a question concerning the timing of the escape: does Peter envision this escape having happened *already*, or does he envision it happening only at that future time when believers see God face to face? As dazzling as the idea of participation in the divine nature is (more on this in the next

⁶ On the usage of δόξα I see here, cf. Harris, 77ff.

paragraph), it seems that the apostle considers his readers to have escaped already. He is speaking of “promises” that “have been given to us” (1:4.1), of power for righteous living that “has been given” (1:3.1); in other words, a victorious Christian life can and should begin *now*. But Peter is quite aware that sin remains a temptation for believers, leaving him with the task of exhorting his readers (frequently, even in only two short epistles) to do right and avoid wrong. Schreiner helpfully suggests “Peter operated with an already-but-not-yet schema. Believers have already escaped the world's corruption in that they belong to God, but the full realization of such a liberation will be theirs on the day of resurrection” (295).

Turning to the question of what it means to participate in the divine nature, there has been diversity of opinion among interpreters. No Christian thinks that he or she will become God, but the question of how deep and profound this participation is or will be is a vexed one. The Orthodox doctrine of theosis is, it seems to me, really a bundle of ideas, not all of which can be judged to be scriptural (for a brief overview from a proponent, see Ware, 225-231). Harris points out that believers will one day be like angels (Lk 20:36) without *becoming* angels, providing an analogy for being like God without becoming God (72). At the same time, there is no sharp distinction to be drawn between what God is like in himself and what his actions are like (cf. Ps 119:68), for he is completely self-consistent (cf. 2 Tim 3:16; on divine simplicity, cf. Bavinck 2: 118ff). Christians do not become God, but they reflect his nature in a way that is anything but superficial: believers are in God (Jn 17:20-23, Eph 1:3ff), and the spiritual fruit that they produce is the Spirit's (Gal 5:22-23); “communion with God is a mystical union. It far exceeds our understanding. It is a most intimate union with God by the Holy Spirit, a union of persons, an unbreakable and eternal covenant” (Bavinck 3: 304). The actions that define believers as believers are not pale, mechanical imitations of God's actions, but vivid, living outpourings of an inner life transformed by communion with God.

1:5-7 Here Peter kicks off a list of virtues: faith, excellence, knowledge, self-control, endurance, piety, brotherly affection, and love. If faith is counted as the starting point rather than as the first virtue, then Simon is giving seven virtues, making use of a number symbolic of perfection.⁷ These are not the *only* virtues, but they are more than adequate as a starting point and summary.

There is some question as to whether or not the virtues listed in these verses are consecutive. On the surface, the structure “add to X Y, and to Y Z” might seem to imply that the items in this list are to be sought one after another in the order listed. Certainly, there is structure to the list, faith being first of necessity (cf. Jn 3:16, Eph 2:8-9), and love being the grand finale (1 Cor 13:13).⁸ But surely no sober and honest Christian would claim to have complete mastery of any of these areas, let alone of all of them precisely in this sequence. There are parallels to this sort of literary structure elsewhere in the ancient world that suggest that “it is doubtful we should understand each virtue as building on the previous one” (Schreiner, 297; see also Davids, 177-179). In short, Christians should give attention to each of the items on this list as necessary.

1:5.1 *And for this very reason:* That is, since God in his power has equipped us to escape sin's snares.

⁷ Interpreting numbers in the Bible symbolically must be done with caution (it is open to many abuses, such as providing false predictions of the timing of Christ's return), but the Bible, like probably any large work of literature, does use symbolism in some measure. The number seven hardly occurs in nature (e.g., the number of petals on a flower is usually a Fibonacci number), so it might have evoked the idea of God's transcendence.

⁸ It might be the case that the list of virtues in Gal 5:22-23 uses the opposite sequence, starting with the most important item and then going down the list from there. But as mentioned on 1:5-7, the exact order is probably not the point.

1:5.2 exhibiting full diligence: “Our approach to learning of God is not to be done in a frivolous, capricious, or cavalier manner. With earnest application, careful study, and inquiry, we are to apply ourselves diligently to every word that has proceeded from God’s mouth” (Sproul, 194). Here, as often, the Bible puts side by side two ideas that might seem contradictory, but really are not, viz. that the power to live rightly can only come from God, yet our response to this situation must not be passivity but activity. “New Testament writers never polarize divine sovereignty and human responsibility. Those whom God has effectively called to virtue are also to practice virtue with energy and intensity” (Schreiner, 299).

1:5.3 supply for your faith: Faith (ΠΙΣΤΙΣ; see Montanari, 1671a-b) is the starting point. Trust in the unseen power of Christ to save from sin’s consequences, not one’s own supposed powers of self-improvement, is the surrender that the Christian life starts from and to which each element of Christian living must be linked. It might be possible to exaggerate the importance of faith to Christianity, but only just. The NT rarely pauses to define words, but Heb 11:1 does, stating, “Faith is the confidence that what we hope for will actually happen; it gives us assurance about things we cannot see” (NLT). It is frequently contrasted with the works of the law of Moses (Gal 2:14ff, to give just one example), for we cannot call it faith in God if we base our confidence in our own plainly visible efforts at self-improvement and benevolence. Victory over sin and live for others are valuable indicators of one’s status as a child of God if their presence in one’s life is merely the visible evidence of the invisible trust that one has in God’s love for them (1 Jn 4:7, 5:4); “we love him, for he first loved us” (4:19).

1:5.4 excellence: This (ἀρετή; see Montanari, 293c) is a rare term in the New Testament, but very popular in epic and in philosophical literature of the Greek world. At one stage, it was most applicable to the skills of a mighty warrior; over time, it came to describe the deeds of the considered life, the ethical outworking of the wise intellect. What Peter seems to have in mind is the need for Christians to move beyond the mediocre, unsatisfied with the idea of life just rolling by aimlessly.

1:5.5 knowledge: For most part this word (γνῶσις; cf. Montanari, 437c) is straightforward. But two matters call for comment. (1) As mentioned on 1:2, within Christian and pseudo-christian circles in the latter part of the first century and beyond, this term was gradually acquiring a new, technical sense, meaning something like, “The esoteric wisdom of the composition of the universe and of our common descent by varying degree from God.” There is much debate about the details, but it seems that an early, still-developing form of this heretical style of religiosity attracted the attention (at least) of Paul and Peter, who resist and undercut it. Later some of the church fathers would labor to combat its teachings and effect. If Peter has proto-gnosticism in mind, he is trying to redeem the term “knowledge.” It might be the case that certain words, terms, symbols, and the like become so associated with false teachings or pernicious misunderstandings that their use should be abandoned (cf. Hos 2:16-17), but in general things should be reclaimed for their proper use. (2) In general, the NT takes a dim view of the accumulation of knowledge (e.g., 1 Cor 8:1). So why is knowledge listed as a basic virtue here? Certain kinds of knowledge are dangerous, or at least liable to misuse, but knowledge of God is necessary for life (Hos 4:6, 2 Tim 3:15). Knowledge disconnected from Christ is ultimately worthless; knowledge is not for its own sake but for the sake of God’s glory (1 Cor 10:31; cf. Bavinck, 1: 53).

1:6.1 self-control: This word (ἐγκράτεια; cf. Montanari, 587b) lit. means “inner strength.” One of the basic, necessary, and difficult tasks of the Christian is restraining his or her own impulses—impulses to say something harsh or self-promoting, to eat unhealthily or excessively, to look at one’s smartphone constantly or rudely, etc.

1:6.2 endurance: This (υπομονη; cf. Montanari, 2229b) is the virtue expressed in the English-language proverb, “When the going gets tough, the tough get going.” Christians need to keep on keeping on when hardships call on a person to deviate from her or his path. A book (which I have not read, but has an evocative title) describes the Christian life as “a long obedience in the same direction.”

1:6.3 piety: This word (ευσεβεια; cf. Montanari 867a) is often rendered “godliness,” but, despite the wide use of this gloss by English translations of Scripture, I would say that it is difficult to get into English. It refers to a respectful, dutiful disposition toward those in heaven on earth to whom you have strong ties, i.e. honor towards parents and respect for God.

1:7.1 brotherly affection: This term (φιλαδελφια, the inspiration for the city name “Philadelphia”; Montanari, 2276a) refers to the kind of love among family or close associates that partly flows naturally but partly has to be cultivated in order to flourish and be beneficial.

1:7.2 love: For more on love (αγαπη; Montanari 8c), cf. on 1 Pet 1:22.5, third paragraph.

1.8 *For when these [virtues] are yours and are increasing, they make you neither useless nor unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ:*⁹ In other words, if you have and continue to grow in these virtues, you will be helpful and fruitful as you live in relationship with the Lord. “Many Christians wish that their growth in Christ were a series of crises in which holiness and other virtues were suddenly infused into them. That is not 2 Peter’s point of view. Instead, our author talks about *growth* in virtue, process instead of crisis” (Davids, 184).

1:9 *By the same token, the person who lacks these [virtues] is blind and shortsighted, having forgotten the cleansing of his former sins:* Schreiner thinks that “cleansing” refers to baptism, though not to the rite as such but to the forgiveness of sins that the rite signifies (303-304). To my mind, it is not certain that the apostle is thinking of baptism in particular rather than to salvation in general, but a strong case can be made for this understanding, since Peter referred to baptism in terms like this in 1 Pet 3:21. In any case, the Christian life begins with a moral cleansing, and it is not meant to be muddled by a life where vice rules over virtue (Rom 6:1ff).

1:10.1 *Therefore all the more, brothers and sisters, be diligent to establish surety in your calling and election:* On “calling,” cf. on 1 Pet 1:15.1.

Since God rules over everything and knows everything, it must not be God who needs confirmation or assurance of a person’s salvation, but rather that person himself or herself (Sproul, 196). Faith is the starting point (1:5.3) and the end point (cf. on 3:18.1) of the Christian faith—yet works play an important confirmatory role (cf. Eph 2:8-10).¹⁰ For if the Christian faith is false in its truth claims, then the religiously-minded individual might derive some comfort from his or her illusory belief, yet will not be substantially helped otherwise; but if the Christian faith is true, then the Holy Spirit dwells within each believer and produces fruit. If believers can look at their lives and see instances where excellence was sought after, where the things of God were taken into the mind, where self-indulgence was rejected, where life’s difficulties did not bring effort to an end, where God and others were given due honor,

⁹ For “useless” see Montanari (290c); the word has undertones of laziness, of unwillingness to take action.

¹⁰ A sharp distinction is sometimes made between Paul’s view of salvation and that of the other apostles. But Schreiner (302), pointing to Gal 5:21 and 1 Cor 6:9-11, finds that Paul is not so different from Peter (301-302); and, pointing to 2 Pet 1:3-4 (everything necessary has been “given” by God), rightly finds that Peter is not so different from Paul.

where fellow Christians were shown care, and where affection was directed outward and not merely inward, and they can observe that progress, however slow, is being made in these areas, then they have tangible evidence that God has begun a good work—and he does not let his projects drop (Phil 1:6).

1:10.2 *for in implementing these things you will absolutely never stumble*: Does stumbling refer to temporary lapses, or ultimate defeat? On the one hand, the same Greek word occurs elsewhere in the NT with the former meaning (Jm 3:2). On the other hand, Peter uses a synonym with the latter meaning in his first epistle (2:8). What might be decisive is the fact that Peter says “absolutely never”: all Christians sin sometimes (many times, in fact). Therefore, Peter must be saying that Christians living out their faith will never face condemnation (the same thought occurs in Rom 8:1-4).¹¹ Human history sadly shows many cases of governmental leaders, political machines, corporate boards, and even local churches discarding someone after years of faithful, dedicated service, but God, as Peter would have heard Jesus say many times (Mat 5:12, 25:31ff, etc.), is not like that. Beyond all contradiction, Jesus’ sheep *will* hear his voice (Jn 10:16).

1:11.1 *For thus*: On a superficial reading, the logic here could be read as: put into practice these seven virtues, and they will grant you entrance into God’s kingdom. But this would contradict the teaching of Scripture elsewhere (Gal 2:15ff, etc.). It is better to see these words are connected to what is most recent: “you will absolutely never stumble,” a glorious hope. So far from falling away into eternal separation from God, believers can look forward to unreserved inclusion in God’s eternal kingdom.¹²

1:11.2 *entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ will be abundantly supplied to you*: It is hard to get into English, but “abundantly” is emphatic in the Greek.

Does Peter imply that there is a possibility of a meager entrance into God’s kingdom? Some interpreters would answer in the affirmative, arguing that a lack of virtue in this life leads to a lack of rewards in the next life.¹³ But a Christian’s “calling and election” (1:10.1) come from God, not himself or herself; will God, who is unstintingly generous (Jm 1:5), call and elect someone, then stingingly allot them a place in his kingdom? Surely not! Note the tenor of this passage as a whole: Peter did not start out marveling at Anatolians’ just-as-precious faith (1:1.2) in order dourly to expect that some among his intended readership will by lack of good works leave themselves a dark and dusty corner of Christ’s blessed realm.

Green (203): “In Jesus’ teaching, as that of Paul, ‘the kingdom of God’ is the rule of God, not a territory, which has begun to be exercised in the present (Matt. 11:12; Mark 1:15; Luke 11:20; Rom. 14:17; 1 Cor. 4:20; Col. 1:13). But the fullness and glory of this kingdom will be revealed in the future, upon Christ’s royal return (Matt. 6:10; Mark 9:1; 1 Cor. 6:9; 15:50; Gal. 5:21; 2 Thes. 1:5; 2 Tim 4:1, 18; cf. 2 Thes. 1:9-10.” The adjective “eternal” recalls such passages as Dan 7:27. The Greek wording might also be a subtle jibe at the worship of the Roman emperor (Davids, 190).

¹¹ Another approach would be to appeal to “in implementing these things” as the condition for never stumbling, but this would generate an unhelpful tautology, viz., when a person is doing the right thing, he or she is not in that moment doing the wrong thing.

¹² A different tack, but in the same vein: the word *OUTΩΣ* could point forward to the fronted adverb *ΠΛΟΥΣΙΩΣ*. In this case, one could render v11, “That is, you will be granted such a rich entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ!” One might expect *OUTΩΣ* to be on the other side of *ΠΛΟΥΣΙΩΣ* if this is the intended sense (cf. Montanari, 1510b), but the conjunction does allow for a wide latitude for position and sense.

¹³ Some in this school of thought would limit this deficit of rewards to the millennial reign of Christ (viz., the 1,000 year interval some see coming between this present age and the new heavens and earth), while others would extend it throughout eternity.

1:12.1 *Therefore, at no time will I be unprepared to remind you about these things—even as you know and have been established in the truth:* Peter threads a needle here, letting his readers know on the one hand that there is nothing truly new here, only reminders of what they already know; and underscoring for them on the other hand the urgency of what he says.

1:12.2 *which is present with you:* The fact that Peter's readers already have access to the truths of the Christian faith is emphasized by the apostle, possibly in order to warn against the appeal by false teachers to new avenues of knowledge (cf. Green, 209-210).

1:13 *But I consider it right, for as long as I am[, so to speak,] in this tent, to prod your memory:* Peter continues in the same vein, adding the thought that his body is not a house, but a tent—not eternal, but temporary. The limited nature of the span of life allotted to us (Ps 102:3, Jm 4:14), and the frailty of our bodies on account of the groaning of this world (Ps 103:14, Rom 8:22) must be kept in mind when we consider what to do with our time, energies, and resources.

1:14 *knowing that the removal of this tent is near (just as indeed our Lord Jesus Christ has indicated to me):* That is to say, Peter expects that his death is not far off. It is hard to say whether he knows this by putting together his own advanced age with the fact that Jesus had predicted an unpleasant death for him in that time period (Jn 21:18-19), or whether he has had a vision or a dream in which Jesus appeared to him and revealed this to him. Either way, this knowledge gives fresh impetus to his mission.

1:15 *at any rate, I will be diligent to keep your memory fresh on every occasion that presents itself until my departure:* By "departure" (ἐξοδος), Peter means of course means his death.¹⁴ Peter is keen to use his remaining days to implant the truths of his epistle into his readers' minds. If a Christian reaches old age, his or her stamina will be reduced, perhaps greatly; yet a believer's usefulness remains (cf. Ps 92:14).

1:16.1 *For we did not follow clever myths:* There is nothing fabricated about the message of Jesus.

1:16.2 *when we made known the power and presence of our Lord Jesus Christ:* By "we," Peter means himself, James, and John, who were with Jesus at the time of his transfiguration (Mat 17:1ff).

The apostle highlights two aspects of Jesus: his "power" and his "presence." "Power" (δυναμις), despite being the inspiration for the English word "dynamite," does not denote explosiveness so much as capacity; Jesus' abilities were unlimited.

"Presence" (παρουσία) is a theologically charged use of a word that sits at the intersection of the ideas of being somewhere and arriving somewhere. In this instance, Peter is not talking about the future return of Jesus to the earth—the apostle is talking about something he saw with his own eyes, as the verse will go on to say. Nor, for the same reason, is he talking about any sort of ordinary presence or arrival, since he and Jesus had gone up to that mountaintop together. Rather, on that day Peter saw in Jesus' face something approaching the fullness of who he really is—eternal God. France (642-643) writes this on the Transfiguration event: "This is a unique incident within Jesus' ministry. The only comparable

¹⁴ It is difficult to assess how much significance to attach to the fact that this Greek word also means "exodus" (coincidentally, the English word "exodus" comes from this Greek term): does Peter imagine his bodily death to be a kind of exodus, a departure from the slavery of this broken world to freedom in the land of God? Or is he simply using established language drawn from the Greek translations of the Bible then in wide use? Montanari (726c) points to Jdg 5:27, where the presence of a related verb in an ancient Greek translation, without a counterpart in the Hebrew original, does suggest that the term had filtered into wide regional use.

moment of supernatural revelation in the gospel [of Matthew] is before that ministry begins, at the baptism of Jesus, when the opening of heaven, the visible descent of the Spirit, and the voice from heaven (speaking the same words as here) create a similarly numinous atmosphere and offer readers a glimpse behind the earthly scene. Jesus' identity as the Son of God, first declared in 3:17, is now reiterated with the same heavenly authority just at the time when his declaration about his coming suffering and death might have led readers to question it. Three aspects of the incident contribute to its christological force: (1) the visible alteration of Jesus demonstrates that he is more than a merely human teacher; (2) his association with Moses and Elijah demonstrates his messianic role; (3) the voice from heaven declares his identity as the Son of God." Davids (201) adds that "our author interprets the Transfiguration not simply as a vision of the power or glory of Jesus, but as a vision of his coming. The two terms 'power' and 'coming' are probably a hendiadys for 'his powerful coming.' The Transfiguration was for 2 Peter, so to speak, a proleptic second coming."

These two terms are summarized with the one term "gloriousness" in the next part of the verse.

That the power and presence is specifically that of "our Lord Jesus Christ" is given emphasis in the Greek in a way that is difficult to get into English.

1:16.3 *On the contrary, we were eyewitnesses of the gloriousness of that man:* I render with "gloriousness" here to distinguish it from the more usual word for "glory" (here it is μεγαλειότης, not δόξα) and to give some idea of the deliberate weightiness of the word used. "Man" here¹⁵ does not imply that Jesus was *only* a man (note what Peter said above in 1:1.3).

For Peter, Jesus' transfiguration was no story or tale, no idea or proposal, no fabrication or myth—it was something that happened before his very eyes, and he, and the two men with him, were powerless to anything but accept the event and what it indicated about Jesus (more on that below).

1:17 *having received from God honor and glory, a voice was borne to him from the majestic glory [of heaven's throne], "This is my beloved Son, with whom I myself am fully pleased":* The effect of God the Father's declaration on the mountain was to reiterate with all emphasis what had been said at his baptism: Jesus has the unique and ineffable status as being the Son, the object of his eternal love and his unreserved approval. Jesus is God's Messiah, the Savior of the world.

The indirect way in which God speaking from heaven is described here is a very Jewish way of framing and heightening the moment (see, e.g., Green, 222-223).

1:18 *And this voice from heaven we heard with our own ears when it came when we were with him on that holy mountain:* The point can hardly be stated too many times: the transfiguration event is not hearsay, but something burned forever into Peter's consciousness. The truths of Christianity are historical truths, turning on actual occurrences, on the real and abiding verdict of God.

1:19.1 *And we have more sure the prophetic word:* An important point to clarify is that "the phrase 'word of prophecy' or 'prophetic word,' when found in Christian writing through the second century, is used only for OT scripture" (Davids, 207); it is not a generic term for prophetic impressions of a different kind. So it is only a slight paraphrase to render "the prophetic word" with "the Bible."

But what is being compared to what? There are several possibilities. (1) The mountaintop experience has made Scripture more certain. This view is possible, yet faces the difficulty that Jews of Peter's day universally took the Bible to be altogether reliable and certain (if subject to widely varying interpretation), so it is not so clear that Peter would feel a need to shore up confidence in it. On the

¹⁵ Translating a Greek demonstrative pronoun, which here, as often, functions in a way that cannot easily be transferred in English syntax.

other hand, in the following verses Peter will feel the need to develop the point that Scripture ultimately comes from God, not humans. (2) The reliability of Scripture is greater than the reliability of any personal experience, even that of an apostle who was there at the Mount of Transfiguration. This may be true, but it seems to cut counter to Peter's earnest contention in the preceding verses that what he saw with his own eyes was true and reliable. (3) The Transfiguration event has made more sure the interpretation of OT prophecy. "The prophetic word of Scripture is made more sure by the transfiguration, for the transfiguration confirms the proper interpretation of the Old Testament, that is, that there is a future coming of Christ for judgment and salvation" (Schreiner, 319). Similarly: "Peter is declaring that what they had heard audibly on the Mount of Transfiguration is confirmed by the Prophets. This is a common motif in the New Testament, that the truth of the New Testament is declared as it represents a fulfillment of something in the Old Testament" (Sproul, 205-206). But—though it is true that the NT constantly appeals to the OT for the validity and significance of the events and ideas it describes—this approach means to require a meaning of "clear," "explicated" for βεβαιος, which does not seem to be the case (cf. Montanari, 382c). (4) "Another possibility is that *"bebaioteron [βεβαιότερον]* should be translated as 'most reliable,' or 'very certain' [cf. von Siebenthal §138d]. On this view Peter was not actually engaging in a comparison at all. He is simply saying that believers have a word from God that is entirely reliable" (Schreiner, 320; see also Green, 226). But while this is possible, it is not clear to me why Peter would use this construction in this place. In the end, the first view is probably best (so also Davids, 207). A belief in the truthfulness of Scripture is of little use if it is utterly detached from observing the course of history, for Scripture makes claims about what has happened and will happen in history, and its truthfulness is verified when what it says is borne out by events. Most especially, the day when Peter, James, and John saw a glimpse of Christ's glory—blinding light on the Mount of Transfiguration replacing the dark clouds that ensconced the mountain at Sinai as Moses' law gave way to Jesus' grace—showing that the prophets had indeed been speaking God's truth all along. God has come to dwell with us.

1:19.2 *as if it was a lamp shining*: In the ancient world, where there were no street lamps, smartphones, or flashlights, lamps were tremendously important and a source of safety and courage in the blackness of night.

1:19.3 *abysmal*: On the rendering cf. Montanari (350b); possibly a more literal rendering would be "arid," in which case Peter mixes his metaphors (dark places and desert areas both being perilous). In any case, the world hates Christ and Christians (Jn 15:18ff) and is full of sin and strife (Rom 1:18ff), danger and disease.

1:19.4 *until the day dawns and the morning star rises*: "The day here is almost certainly the day of the Lord. In the Old Testament the day of the Lord is a day of judgment and salvation, when those who oppose God will be punished and those who love him will be delivered (Isa 13:6,9; Ezek 13:5; 30:3; Joel 1:15; 2:1,11,31; 3:14; Amos 5:18,20; Obad 15; Zeph 1:7,14; Mal 4:5... In the New Testament the day of the Lord is also the day of Christ (2 Cor 1:14; Phil 1:6,10; 2:16)" (Schreiner, 321). The morning star refers to the coming of the promised messiah, Jesus of Nazareth, to deliver his people from the darkness of this sin-ridden world (see further Green, 228f).

Davids (210), pointing to 1 Cor 13:8-10, remarks, "One treasures a love letter while the beloved is absent, but once he or she is present, the letter is laid aside and exchanged for personal contact." Scripture will not be necessary once we see Jesus face to face. Yet, for the present while we mourn and wait, it is absolutely essential.

1:19.5 *in your hearts*: In context, this does not mean that this event is purely internal: see Green (229), who points to the context, verbal and conceptual parallels in literature from the time, and 2 Cor 4:6.

1:20.1 *knowing this first of all*: The ideas that are to follow (in the next part of this verse and in the next) are of utmost importance.

1:20.2 *no prophecy is one's own prerogative*; The Greek is somewhat ambiguous, giving rise to various translations. The two basic options are expressed thus: "no prophecy in Scripture ever came from the prophet's own understanding" (NLT); or "no prophecy of Scripture is of any private interpretation" (NKJV). While the second translation states a truth, inasmuch as the Bible is not to be interpreted however any reader may wish,¹⁶ the first translation fits the context (see the following verse):¹⁷ the idea is that the Scriptures come from God, not men (though he used them to write Scripture), and so there is a seriousness to how the Bible should be approached and an authority which it possesses that no merely human documents or pronouncements could possibly have. The hottest takes, the latest research, the cleverest reasoning—all pale in comparison to God's holy word.

1:21 *on the contrary, holy men of God, carried by the Holy Spirit, spoke*. "Holy" is a favorite adjective on Peter's (Ac 3:14, 1 Pet 1:12, 15, 16, 2:5, 9, 3:5, 15, 2 Pet 1:18, 21, 3:2, 11). See on 1 Pet 1:16.2.¹⁸

The phrase "moved by the Holy Spirit" Peter "did not mean that Scripture came about because people had religious experiences that gave them a sense of ecstasy so that, as their emotions were moved by the presence of the Spirit of God, they gave voice to the emotion and declared what they [fancifully] believed to be the things of God. Peter means that the content of the Word of God does not arise by human will. Its origin and authority are found in God alone" (Sproul, 211). To be clear, I suspect the process of composing the Scriptures often was an intensely emotional experience, but the point stands: the Bible is not *merely* the work of men, but the work of men whose work originated in and from God.

"Speaking" is an appropriate verb in a predominately oral culture, and also captures the nuance that in many cases (cf., e.g., Jer 36:4-8), the author of a book of the Bible did not take a quill in hand, but verbally spoke, others writing down the message (then or later).

2:1-22.1 Chapter two (and, to a lesser extent, chapter three) of 2 Peter bears a resemblance to the epistle of Jude that can hardly be coincidental. It is possible, but unlikely, that both are drawing from a common source, now lost to us. But the probability is that one is adapting the work of the other. Most scholars think that Peter is adapting Jude (so Jude was written before 2 Peter). This is probably correct, for a number of reasons. For instance, the material in question takes up almost all of Jude's letter, but a much smaller portion of Peter's; it makes more sense that a later writer would expand and incorporate,

¹⁶ "When engaged in disputes as to the interpretation of a particular Scripture text, I have often been rebutted with these words: 'Well, that's just your interpretation.' Of course it is my interpretation, since I just stated it as such. My objector means that I interpret it one way and he in another way and that we are all entitled to interpret it however we wish. However, God has never given us the right to be wrong about the Word of God. That is why we [must] guard our [methods of] interpretation of Scripture carefully, looking at the best commentaries that we can find, studying diligently, and not relying on our naked ability. We [should] consult the giants of church history and the confessions of the church. Though they do not have binding authority over us, they certainly can inform us and help us out of errors born of our ignorance" (Sproul, 210).

¹⁷ As an example of a commentator in agreement with me on this point, see Green (230ff); for an opposing view, see Davids (210ff).

¹⁸ Some manuscripts have, "on the contrary men, carried by the Holy Spirit, spoke from God." In Greek these two versions are visually very similar, so whichever reading is incorrect is probably simply a mistake, not an example of theologically-motivated intervention. And the thrust is the same either way: God's Word, the Bible, came as a result of his Spirit's guiding of certain individuals as they spoke.

rather than drastically reduce, esteemed material so pertinent to the problems at hand. In doing this, Peter is employing a respected literary strategy of his day, viz. adapting a work likely to be known to his readers (on this practice, and its distinction from plagiarism, see Green, 161-162). This approach allows Peter on the one hand to show respect for Jude's work by adopting Jude's general approach to describing the same (or at least a very similar) problem, and on the other hand to reshape the writing to suit his own emphases.¹⁹

But the question of whether Jude or 2 Peter comes first is not greatly consequential. More important is the fact that, either way, the same problem (viz., of false teachers within the Church itself) was troubling more than one early leader. It was, and is, needful repeatedly to bring to mind the dangers that the Church faces and watchfully to anchor oneself in the heart of God for sinners.

2:1-22.2 The main idea in chapter two (an idea hinted at in chapter one and developed further in chapter three) is that even in the holy gatherings of the Church there can be expected to appear false teachers, and these men pose immense danger. Peter takes great pains to paint a grim picture of these people. If his language seems excessive, note (1) that he is borrowing from literary conventions of the time,²⁰ and (2) the high stakes involved, viz. the very salvation of souls (see esp. on 2:20-23 below).

Putnam, pulling together a number of NT texts, compiles the following list of traits of false teachers: "First, false teaching preys on the spiritually immature... Second, false teaching can be the product of distorted interpretations of Scripture by those not firmly established in the truth... Third, false teaching grows out of ungodly ambition, ignorance, and conceit... Fourth, false teaching sometimes stems from a desire for material gain... Fifth, false teaching can result from and lead to inappropriate sensuality and sexual immorality... Sixth, false teaching is sometimes attributed [by the NT] to demonic deception... Seventh, false teachers seek to divide the body of Christ... Finally, false teaching can come from apostates and deviant teachers within the church" (208-211, italics removed).

2:1.1 *But there were indeed false prophets among the people:* That is, among the people of Israel in the OT. "The most destructive threat to the people of God in the Old Testament was not the armies of the Philistines, the Assyrians, or the Amalekites, but the false prophets within their gates" (Sproul, 214).

2.1.2 *factions:* The Greek word (αἵρεσις) is the basis for the English word "heresies," but this connection is somewhat misleading. Nowadays, heresy refers generally to some idea far removed from the consensus or liable to provoke strongly negative reactions or, in a Christian context, specifically to some teaching that actually or supposedly fatally undermines the possibility of salvation. But the Greek terms Peter uses refers to splitting off from the main group. When that main group is the Church, God's holy nation (see 1 Pet 2:9), divergence of this kind is not simply an outside perspective or a new way of doing things, but a departure from the place where God's saving truth is to be found.

¹⁹ If the minority position is taken, such that 2 Peter is supposed to predate Jude, the previous two sentences are still true when the names of the two men are swapped.

²⁰ Andrieu surveys polemical literature from the Greco-Roman period, and concludes that while a writer could not paint a portrait of his opponent(s) that was radically at odds with reality, "in passages where the attitudes, motivation and character of the adversaries dominated, their depiction was determined by the strongly subjective experiences and perceptions of the writer and by his personal interpretation of their actions within the framework of an existential ideological conflict. In these texts the historical reference would certainly diminish" (411); the description, in other words, was not intended to be or read by the audience as overly literal and specific, but was understood as putting "pressure on the readers/audience to dissociate with them and reaffirm their allegiance to author's position" (412).

2:1.3 *who deny the Sovereign who bought them*: The question of whether these teachers are (or were) believers will be addressed under 2:20-23 below.

2:1.4 *instigating for themselves sudden destruction*: The OT speaks at points of evil men experiencing a sudden reversal of their fortunes (e.g., Ps 64:7, 112:10).

2:2 *And many follow them in their [example of] insolence; because of them the way of truth is libeled*. This, too, has OT precedent (Isa 52:5, Eze 36:20). Paul similarly is troubled at the thought of the reputation of the Church suffering because of bad behavior from its members (1 Cor 14:23, 1 Thes 4:12, 1 Tim 3:7, etc.).²¹

2:3.1 *They also traffic in deceitful, contrived tales*: In sharp contrast to the factual basis of the Christian faith (1:16ff), the false teachers use lies to get what they want.

2:3.2 *Theirs is an ancient judgment that will not be idle, and their destruction will not sleep*: The OT, already ancient in Peter's day, is filled with pronouncements of coming judgment—entire sections of Isaiah and Jeremiah, for instance, foretell judgments in vivid detail—and God is sure to deliver on his promises (Davids, 224).

2:4.1 *if God did not spare the angels who sinned*: What angelic sin is Peter referencing? Davids (225ff) and Green (249ff) refer to Gen 6:1ff.²² Sproul (220-221), by contrast, thinks that the reference is to Satan and the other evil angels engaging in their initial rebellion against God, not to the events of Gen 6. The apostle does not give us a detailed description, his main point not being in the exact nature of the angelic sin but in the fact that God remained in control and reserved a judgment for them. Likewise, the presence of false teachers in the Church has not caught God by surprise, nor will he be sparing in his judgment on them.

2:4.2 *but bound them with the chains of the darkness of Tartarus while they are kept for [the day of] judgment*: Sometimes translations describe the place where the angels go as “hell,” but the Greek here (ταρταρος) is different. In Greek mythology, Tartarus is the most remote part of the underworld in Greek mythology. After everything Peter has said about truth and mythology, he is certainly not endorsing Greek myth, but using a widely known image (Green, 251). God's ultimate removal of the wicked from the righteous will be utter and irrevocable.

2:5 *and [if] the ancient world he did not spare (but he protected a group of eight including Noah, a proclaimer of righteousness), striking the world of the ungodly with utter destruction*: God brings judgment not only on sinful angels, but on sinful people—even if they constitute the vast majority of humanity, as in Noah's day. But in Noah's day, God did not sweep away the unjust with the just, and just as he preserved Noah and the others, so he will preserve those in the Church whose trust is in God—even if their leaders are wicked.

2:6-10 Peter develops in some detail the comparison on the one hand between Sodom and Gomorrah and Lot and on the other hand with present false teachers and true believers. For many, the surprise here is the positive light in which Lot is cast. Nowadays there is a certain tendency for people to be

²¹ It is not as though, however, broad (and changeable) cultural concerns are at the heart of Paul's injunctions—see Knight, 316-318.

²² Cf. the (related but ultimately separable) debates about Peter's meaning in 1 Pet 3:19f.

defined by their very worst moments, rather than the sweep of their lives and the disposition of their hearts.

2:7 and [if] righteous Lot, who was being worn out by the conduct of unethical, insolent people: “Lot wavered and doubted, but Peter addressed readers who [possibly] also were wavering because of the appearance of false teachers” (Schreiner, 342).

2:8 what I mean is that that righteous man was being tortured in his righteous soul day after day as he dwelt with them by the lawless deeds he saw and heard: In English, the term “sodomy” generally refers to male homosexual activity, and this can give the impression that Sodom, together with Gomorrah, was condemned solely for that kind of sin. In fact, as abhorrent as homosexuality is, the sins of Sodom and Gomorrah were numerous, involving at least pride and neglect of the poor (Eze 16:49) as well as homosexuality and rape (Gen 19:5ff, Jd 7). Still, Peter does have sexual perversion particularly in mind (as 2:10.1 shows). Modern America has to a large extent normalized homosexuality, and while homosexuality should not be viewed as the sum of all evil, and while those who practice homosexuality should be warned on the basis of loving concern for their well being and humble acceptance of God’s wisdom and not with vitriol or violence, the contemporary scene is one that should be recognized as torturing our souls.

2:9 testing: This is “a term that normally refers to tests that one faces as a result of his or her commitment to Christ and his mission. According to Luke Jesus looked on his whole life as characterized by these trials (Luke 22:28), and they are referred to frequently in the NT (e.g., Jas 1:2; 1 Pet 1:6)” (Davids, 231).

2:10.1 especially those who go after impure bodily desires: While Christian ethical teaching has sometimes focused excessively on sexual sin, making it seem as though the Church only exists to be prudish, it has to be said that (1) frequently across history and cultures, religious aberrations have been accompanied by sexual looseness; and (2) sexual impropriety is rampant in today’s society, and today’s pastors must not fail in their duties to warn people about the dangers here and to call God’s people to the higher and better lifestyles (viz., married sexuality, or unmarried abstinence).

2:10.2 Bold, presumptuous, not trembling at glorious things: Arrogance and irreverence are often the watchwords of false teachers. While believers have no need to live in terror of demons, neither are they to belittle them, mock them, or make light of them. Modern approaches to demon activity tend either to ignore them altogether or to barrage them with insults or with claims of power over them that seem to be on shaky ground in the light of this verse.

2:12.1 like irrational animals: Time spent around individual animals discloses many layers of personality and thought in them, and scientific study of animals in general increasingly has revealed vast levels of complexity. Why, then, does Peter describe them as “irrational” here? The fact that the apostle is making use of a commonplace of his day only partly explains the matter, since the ancient world certainly had a significant degree of respect for the abilities and the value of animals. If rationality is equated with abilities such as that by which information is stored in the memory and put to use in solving problems, or that by which generalizations made from particular experiences and observations, then animals certainly have rationality—but not in the same degree, or not in such a variegated way, as human beings. As someone has put it, apes have yet to land a spacecraft on the moon. Sometimes a difference of degree becomes for all practical purposes a difference in kind, so that it is fair to speak of animals as “irrational.” Alternatively, one could argue that there are one or more aspects of human intelligence that are

fundamentally different from animal intelligence. As Professor Alan Charles Kors has observed, no species of animal has an intellectual history (with, at most, narrow exceptions, such as the identification of fruitful hunting grounds), while human ways of thinking can be seen in constant flux as the camera lens of observation shifts its focus from one culture to another or from one time period to another.

Peter's point in any case is that the people in question have in large measure set aside their humanity, for in setting out on a life of sin they have embraced the illogical, and, more to the point, walked eyes-wide-open into the trap set before them. Sin is always, in the final analysis, warped, perverted, and self-destructive, and those who live in it are fools of the worst kind. Rats who are, or ought to be, fully aware of the fact that entering the cage with the bait will mean that no exit will be possible, have waltzed right in.

2:12.2 *born to be captured and destroyed*: Peter is not discussing ecology here. Proper care for the planet is implied to God's original directive to humanity in Genesis chapter one, but the apostle's task here is to capture in vivid, even visceral, language the senseless sin of the opponents. As animals so often head into danger, leading to their death, so these people invite their own demise.

2:14 *people under a curse*: Lit. "children of a curse," but this a Hebrew/Aramaic idiom. Those not covered by the grace of God are under a curse (Gal 3:10), their evil deeds bringing God's wrath (Rom 1:18ff).

2:15 *having followed the way of Balaam, son of Bosor, who loved the wages of unrighteousness*:²³ The story of Balaam is recorded in Num 22:1ff. It is difficult to assess what exactly Balaam's relationship with God was. On the one hand, he receives and accurately passes on messages from the Lord, and insists that he must be faithful in discharging this duty. On the other hand, he does not seem to serve the Lord out of any love for him, or to have any interest in God's people. This sort of ambiguous relationship with God might be part of why Peter brings him up here, for the relationships between the false teachers and God is somewhat similar. But the main point of contact between Balaam and the challenges facing Peter's readers lies in the appeal that the prospect of money, not any sincere sense that he was following God's will, was what led Balaam to cooperate with Balak's messengers.

2:17.1 *These people are wells without water*: "Wells" (πηγαί) might be a word play on πηγός ("violent, impetuous," Montanari 1661b). At any rate, the imagery is clear enough: the teachers promise to be of great assistance, but in reality offer no help at all.

2:17.2 *clouds driven by stormwinds*: Insubstantial, and controlled by passing fads (cf. Eph 4:14).

2:17.3 *for whom the deepest darkness is kept forever*: It has been observed that hell is sometimes described as fire and darkness, complete destruction and lingering pain and regret. It seems, then, that no single image literally or fully captures what that place is like. Its true essence, in fact, is separation from God (2 Thes 1:9, Rev 22:15), who alone is light and life (Ps 36:9).

2:19 *promising freedom to them, even as they themselves are slaves of corruption (whatever one surrenders to one is in fact a slave to)*: The teachers make their teaching appealing, promising what few would turn down, freedom. "The promise of freedom, however, is specious since the teachers themselves are not free" (Davids, 247). However much they hide or misrepresent the sin in their lives, sin, with all of its self-destructive effects, is what drives their thoughts and behavior.

²³ On the Greek at this point, see http://jbtc.org/v27/TC-2022_Himes.pdf.

2:20-23: Are the false teachers warned about in this chapter believers or unbelievers? Here are some extracts from commentators (my own comments will follow in the next paragraph). Sproul (234): “Peter is not describing pagans here but apostates. One cannot apostatize apart from having made a profession of faith, but such profession was false to begin with. These are people who joined the church for every reason except the right one. They never were true believers. They are unbelievers in the midst of believers, and they will sooner or later depart from the presence of the church. As John tells us, ‘They went out from us, but they were not of us; for if they had been of us, they would have continued with us; but they went out that they might be made manifest, that none of them were of us’ (1 John 2:19).” Schreiner (331): “I would suggest that Peter used phenomenological language. In other words, he described the false teachers as believers because they made a profession of faith and gave every appearance initially of being genuine believers. Peter did not refer to those who had been outside the community of faith but to those who were [by regular association, at least] part of the church and perhaps even leaders among God’s people.”²⁴ To Green (307), by contrast, “This is genuine apostasy,” by which he means loss of salvation previously obtained. Davids (248) seems to reason similarly.

Viewed in isolation, Peter’s words in this chapter can be read as saying that some people—wicked teachers, at least—can and will lose their salvation. But a wider reading of Scripture (e.g., Jn 5:25, 10:7-9) argues against seeing that idea taught here. Of particular interest is the parallel passage, viz. the epistle of Jude. There (v1) the writer describes the false teachers as “not having the Spirit,” whereas we know (Rom 8:9) that all believers have the Spirit. But does 2 Pet 2:1.3 (denying the Sovereign who bought them) require us to understand that Peter views the false teachers as unbelievers? Again, the words could fairly be read that way, but there are also reasons to give them a second look. For one thing, in the parallel passage (Jd 4), Jude describes them as denying “our Lord” (not “their Lord”), and goes on in the following verse to compare them to “those who did not believe.” For another thing, the present passage (like its parallel) stresses (1) the deceptive nature of the prophets and (2) the ethical (not principally doctrinal) nature of their wickedness. That is, the false teachers confess Christ’s purchase of themselves, sing about it with those they claim to be their brothers and sisters in Christ, and otherwise give every verbal sign of being a Christian; the problem is not any (open) verbal denial of the truths of Christianity, but a behavioral denial.²⁵ Peter’s “the Sovereign who bought them,” then, might be intended ironically.²⁶

I do not think, then, that this passage teaches that genuine believers can lose their salvation. However, it is a passage that can cause considerable discomfort, neither easily fitting into tidy theological categories, nor promising a quick identification of dangerous leaders. As long as it does not veer into panic (2 Tim 1:7), this discomfort is a good thing: this epistle is designed to spur God’s people on to mindfulness and diligence (3:1, 11).

2:22 “Dogs were not household pets among the Jews; they were despised scavengers” (Sproul, 243). Pigs, too, were commonly regarded with disdain, especially among the Jews. The point is that the false

²⁴ Schreiner offers various arguments against the idea that the opponents are merely Christians at risk of losing heavenly rewards, most notably that “the flood and Sodom and Gomorrah are types of eternal judgment,” and “it does not make much sense to say the last judgment is worse than the first (2:20)... if the people described will ultimately experience eschatological life” (364).

²⁵ “From a modern standpoint we immediately imagine them to be rejecting some statement in the creed, for example, the Apostolic or Nicene Creeds. This is reinforced if we have already imported a modern concept of heresy into this passage. But in fact in this passage our author never accuses these teachers of doctrinal error, but rather of behavior aberrations. Their problems are not so much heterodoxy as heteropraxy” (Davids, 221).

²⁶ Another approach would be to posit some sort of provisional redemption offered by Christ as the cross, an offer that is real on his part but ultimately not accepted by the false teachers. This approach, however, seems to me to read in elements not hinted at in the context, and to demand an approach to soteriology that I, for my part, do not see borne out elsewhere in Scripture.

teachers' exposure to, and seeming acceptance of, the cleansing truths of Christianity has not really helped them, for they will of their own accord return to their natural environments of filth.

3:1.1 *This is now the second epistle I am writing to you:* Only under strained hypotheses can we imagine Peter to be alluding to anything other than the book we call 1 Peter. How long the gap was between these two letters we do not know, though probably it was not a large gap, since Peter assumes those reading this epistle will be (at least broadly) familiar with his first.

3:1.2 *beloved, in which I am stirring up your sincere minds:* In calling his readers "beloved," in stating that he is reminding them of what they already know, and in calling their minds "sincere," Peter is continuing in the same spirit in which he wrote 1 Peter (cf. 2:2.4 there, second paragraph)—rather than assuming, as many preachers seem to, that his readers are not working, praying, or giving enough, he takes the stance that his readers are serious about their Christian faith, though, like anyone, in need of reminder at times.

3:2 *your apostles:* This might mean "the particular apostles who evangelized and taught the churches receiving this letter" (Schreiner, 371). Or perhaps it means "the apostles, whose ministry was for your benefit" (cf. 1 Cor 3:5-9, 21-23). Notice the connection with the prophets, as connection repeatedly made in Ephesians (2:20, 3:5, 4:11). The key point in any case is that these men transmitted the message about suffering, apostasy, and the need for patience in holiness; and they did these things in obedience to the direct command of Jesus Christ (Mat 28:20).

3:3 *in the last days deceivers will come:* On "the last days" see also 1 Pet 4:7.1.

3:4.1 *Where is the promise of his coming?:* The false teachers question whether it really is true that Jesus will come again to the earth. From Peter's emphasis on the need for holiness in the following verses, and in view of the licentiousness of the false teachers flagged in the previous chapter, the main thing that the false teachers seem to want to deny is that judgment for sin is coming.

3:4.2 *After all, from the moment the fathers passed away, everything has continued as it has since the beginning of creation:* Who are "the fathers"? Sproul thinks that "Peter was referencing the early church fathers who walked with Jesus, the early martyrs, some of whom had already died" (248). This is probably anachronistic, however. The reference is more likely to such men as Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Moses (who lived between a millennium and a half and two millennia before Peter's day). The argument is astonishingly close to modern ideas (particularly deism): year after year passes with humanity continuing in the behaviors it has always indulged in, yet Jesus does not intervene by coming in judgment, suggesting that he never will.

3:5-6 But it is not as though God hasn't intervened before. God did intervene on a massive scale in the days of Noah (Gen 6:11ff). The false teachers, being leaders in the church, must be faulted for bypassing this biblical account which so thoroughly disproves their view of divine non-intervention.

3:5.1 *They say this because they willfully forget:*²⁷ "People tend to have selective memories" (Sproul, 248). The false teachers' "ignorance is not merely an unfortunate circumstance. They are marked as those who have willingly passed over the fundamental truths from Scripture that Peter now elaborates" (Green, 319).

²⁷ Another way to understand the Greek is something along the lines of "They say this because, desiring to scoff at the idea of coming judgment, they forget" (cf. Davids, 267-268). But this approach seems a bit forced.

3:5.2 *that the former heavens and earth were fashioned by the word of God out of water and through water:* The Genesis account of creation (Gen 1:1ff) makes much of the presence and dividing of water in the formative days of the earth, and this idea what explored to a significant extent in theological literature of the late second temple period. So Peter's readers, and the false teachers with them, would all readily accept that a shorthand for how God formed the earth was out of and through water—even if the exact mechanics might not have been altogether clear to them, and certainly are not to us. The train of thought among the false teachers might have been that God would not destroy his creation, but rather allows all natural materials and laws to continue as they always have. Ironically, this is just a new, more comprehensive version of the old (and altogether wrong) theory that God would not allow a place dedicated to his worship to see destruction (Jer 7:1ff, 26:1ff).²⁸ But the apostle points out that the very element that was so foundational to the creation of the world was also that through which God brought about its destruction. Yes, Peter says, God's providence watches over his creation; but that very oversight of God will bring about the eradication of sin.

3:7 *And the heavens and earth which presently exist by his word are [similarly] being kept for a fire reserved for the day of judgment and of the destruction of impious people:* God does not relate to his creation based on fundamentally different principles after the flood of Noah than he did before then. If anything, there is a heightened accountability on humankind's part.

3:8-9a *But do not let this one thing be forgotten by you, beloved: with the Lord, one day as a millennium, and a millennium is as one day. 9 The Lord is not slow to keep his promise (for some think it slow):* (A millennium is a span of 1,000 years.) "In one sense the marking of time is irrelevant to God because he transcends it" (Schreiner, 379). Long spans of time do not tire him out, causing him to forget his promises (Ps 90:2, 121:3). Men, whose days are like a shadow (1 Chron 29:15), should not call the Ancient of Days (Dan 7:9) slow.

3:9b *but is patient with us, not desiring that anyone perish, but that everyone would accept repentance:* How does the implication that God does not get everything he wants²⁹ square with verses that seem to say the opposite (Ps 115:3, to name one of many)? Schreiner distinguishes between God's "decretive will" and his "desired will": "God desires the salvation of all in one sense, but he does not ultimately ordain that all will be saved" (381). In other words, it brings God no happiness when some perish. Sproul relates the term "any" specifically to "us": "Peter is clearly distinguishing the believer from the unbeliever, the scoffer, and the false prophet" (250). "If the kingdom had been finished a hundred years ago, none of us would have made it. God is not going to consummate the kingdom unless or until every one of His elect is brought into it" (251). Both these approaches express a truth, as long as the first view is not twisted to mean that God is well-meaning, but powerless; and assuming the second view is not taken with a smug, self-assured attitude ("I thank you, Lord, that you have not made me like others"), but with a humble gratitude ("Have mercy on me, a sinner") one would wish for others (cf. Rom 9:3).

3:10 *This day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night, and the earth and its works will be burned:* Just as a thief with any skill at all comes at an unexpected time, so Jesus Christ will come in judgment at a moment the false teachers do not anticipate. This imagery the apostle is borrowing from none other

²⁸ A related error in modern times, it seems to me, is that the need for a church or denomination to maintain a good reputation provides a basis for concealing failings or suppressing critique.

²⁹ The apostle has recently (2:3) spoken at length of "an ancient judgment that will not be idle," so he cannot mean here that God desires that no one will perish, and no one will.

than Jesus himself (Mat 24:43)—the time when his Lord spoke these words must have been burned eternally into the fisherman’s mind.

On the second part of the verse, see below on 3:10-13.

3:11 *So then, with everything to be destroyed in this manner, what sort of people ought you to be, [living] with holy conduct and piety:* The false teachers seem to have reasoned that “if there is no final judgment, then those parts of conventional morality that make sense only in light of final judgment (versus those parts that make sense when viewed with enlightened self-interest with regard to life in this age) would not be binding” (Davids, 246-247).

On holiness, see on 1 Pet 1:16.2. On piety, see on 2 Pet 1:6.3.

3:12.1 *Waiting eagerly for and hastening along the coming of the day of God:* “Hastening the day”: Sproul’s honesty is commendable when he says, “I do not know why Peter says this or what he meant by it” (257-258). Schreiner has some helpful comments on questions around divine sovereignty (390-391). I think the apostle’s meaning is, “Pray for the Lord to come soon,” in the vein of Rev 22:20.³⁰

The “day of God” is the final day, the day of judgments (often referred to in the OT as “the day of the Lord,” or even, “that day”). That the constant NT expectation that Jesus Christ will return to the earth is here referred to as “the day of God” is of course quite significant for what the earliest Christians—the apostle Peter, not least—thought of Jesus (cf. on 1:1.3 above).

3:12.2 *for the sake of whom the heavens will be burned and destroyed and the elements will be superheated and melt:* Because of Jesus’ coming, the very world will melt away. Once again (cf. 2:1.4, 2:2, 2:3.2, etc.), Peter draws on a range of OT texts (e.g., Ps 46:6, 68:2, 97:5, Mic 1:4).

3:13 *But we, in view of his promise, are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells:* Peter might be thinking of Isa 65:17ff, 66:22ff, or to a promise in the same vein made by Jesus during his earthly ministry. Good and evil are not in perpetual struggle, as some teach. One day, the righteous, and they alone, will live with God on the earth. Humanity’s purpose will be fulfilled, its happiness full.

3:10-13 Is God reneging on his promise to Noah not to destroy the earth (Gen 9:11) by using the technicality that he will do so with fire, not water? It seems to me hard to avoid this conclusion, if a literal, physical destruction of the earth is foreseen here. But I think that Peter is not talking about a physical destruction of the earth, but a spiritual renewal. Appealing to the frequent use of non-literal, apocalyptic language in the Bible, Sproul says: “We are not to understand Peter’s words here to mean that God is going to burn up the universe and throw it away. There will be an end to the world as we know it... However, God is not going to annihilate the old in order to create the new. Instead he is going to redeem the old, shaping it into what He wants it to be” (257). Bavinck (4: 717) writes that, sure enough, “the New Testament proclaims that heaven and earth will pass away (Matt. 5:18; 24:35; 2 Pet 3:10; 1 John 2:17; Rev 21:1), that they will perish and wear out like clothing (Heb. 1:11); dissolve (2 Pet 3:10), be burned with fire (3:10), and be changed (Heb. 1:12). But none of these expressions implies a destruction of substance. Peter, for example, expressly teaches that the old earth, which originated as a result of the separation of waters, was deluged with water and so perished (2 Pet. 3:6), and that the present world would also perish, not—thanks to the divine promise—by water but by fire. Accordingly,

³⁰ It might be relevant to mention here that that prayer was not something essentially new as of the writing of Revelation, but an old prayer of the Church—so old as to appear at times in Aramaic (1 Cor 16:22), the principle language of Jesus and of the earliest Christians.

with reference to the passing of the present world, we must no more think of a destruction of substance than [we would] with regard to the passing of the earlier world in a flood. Fire burns, cleanses, purifies [cf. 1 Pet 1:7].”³¹ Alternatively, we could grant that the earth will be destroyed, but hasten to add, with the apostle, that it will be remade; if, as some have argued, the postdiluvian earth was in a sense a remade earth, much more so will the new earth be a renewed, restored earth, suitable for the righteous forever to live with God. “The end is not for fear but for hope” (Green, 334).

3:14 *Therefore, beloved, while you wait for these things, be diligent to be found peacefully in him without spot or blemish:* “The two most important words with respect to the last things of which the Bible speaks are *vigilance* and *diligence*. We should be watching, but not from some mountaintop, disengaged from the work of the kingdom of God. While we are watching, waiting, and being vigilant, we are called to be diligent concerning our sanctification” (Sproul, 258).

Schreiner points out the link here to the beginning (1:5.2) of the letter (393).

“Eschatology and ethics are firmly wed in 2 Peter... The destruction of the world is not related to satisfy curiosity. Knowing the outcome of this world should motivate believers to live a new quality of life” (Schreiner, 388-389).

3:15.1 *and count our Lord’s patience as salvation:* As the apostle has demonstrated, it is not that God forgets or is slow to keep his promises; rather, the Lord is giving time for people to accept his salvation.

3:15.2 *just as our beloved brother Paul, according to the wisdom given to him has written to you:* Modern scholarship has tended to drive a wedge between Paul and the other apostles, but “Peter acknowledges Paul as his beloved brother, despite their various points of dispute along the way” (Sproul, 259). Nor does Peter jealously guard the believers of Asia Minor as his personal sphere of influence; rather, he happily acknowledges that they have benefited immensely from Paul’s ministry of writing. I suspect that “to you” here is used in a general way (“for your benefit,” we might paraphrase), though perhaps he is thinking specifically of those epistles that made their way to Asia Minor (Galatians, Ephesians, Colossians, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Philemon).

Nowhere does Paul use the exact language “count our Lord’s patience as salvation,” but the apostle unceasingly speaks of God’s forbearance with our sins and of the grace to be found in Jesus Christ, who will raise up all who have believed in him on the last day.

3:16.1 *as in all his epistles he speaks about these things:* That is, Paul constantly speaks of the salvation to be found in God’s patience (v15). Just as the believers in Asia Minor possess a faith just as precious as that of the apostles (1:1.2), the apostolic message preached to them is in all essentials the very same message preached to all the world.

3:16.2 *These things contain certain difficult elements:* “We note here also that even Peter struggled with some of what Paul wrote; when we struggle with it, we know therefore that we are in good company” (Sproul, 259).

3:16.3 *which the foolish and unstable twist:* The word “foolish” here (αμαθης) can simply mean “ignorant” in the sense of not being aware of something, but it often contains moral connotations,

³¹ Schreiner is reluctant to commit to a view as to whether or not the present heavens and earth will be physically destroyed (392). Davids (283ff) seems to say that there will be a physical destruction, but rightly sees the main idea in any case as the exposure and elimination of sin. Green does not comment on the question of destruction.

referring even to brutality or evil (cf. Montanari, 101). The term “unstable” forms a contrast with “stability” in the next verse.

3:16.4 *as indeed [they twist] the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction*: While Peter singles out Paul’s epistles for special mention,³² the whole of the Bible finds itself suffering abuse at the hands of these disingenuous interpreters. But they are the ones who will suffer in the end, for in neglecting the Scriptures that reveal the way of salvation (2 Tim 3:15), they invite their own destruction.

An important detail here is that Peter implies (“the rest of Scriptures”) that the various letters of Paul (Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, etc.) are already recognized as Scripture (alongside Genesis, Exodus, etc.). This is in contrast to a widespread but incorrect idea that it was an exceedingly long and gradual process that they (and other books of the NT) came to be considered canonical; nor is it the case that an ecumenical council of the church bestowed canonicity on certain books. The letters of Paul—and, it is not hard to surmise, most or all other NT books—were quickly (in some cases, perhaps instantly) recognized as being inspired by the Holy Spirit. All the more then, ought we to follow their light, as a lamp shining in an abysmal place (1:19).

3:17 *You then, beloved, knowing these things beforehand, be on your guard, so that you might not be carried off with any lie of the impious and fall from your own stability*: Christians cannot be apathetic. With warmth (“beloved”), Peter warns his readers that the steady foundation they have in Christ must remain what they build their lives on; the foundation must not become for them a thing of the past (cf. on 2:20-23).³³

3:18.1 *but be growing in the grace and knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ*: While the Greek is a bit ambiguous (in particular, is the knowledge spoken of here knowledge of or knowledge from Jesus?), probably “what we have here are two gifts of Jesus: we continue growing...[1] in the grace/favor that Jesus gives and [2] in the knowledge that he gives, a knowledge that is surely a knowledge of him (since without growing the knowledge of God and of Jesus it is difficult to conceive of any growth in the Christian sphere that could be called true knowledge), but at the same time more than just knowledge of him, [but also] including knowledge of the Scriptures, knowledge that allows us to discern the falsehood of the false teachers and to recognize their seduction, knowledge that keeps us stable in every way” (Davids, 316-317).

There is a sense (see v17) in which growth in the Christian faith is one of effort and diligence, but more important is the sense (our present verse) in which the key is continuing to receive. To receive more and more grace is to become more and more dependent; to know Jesus more and more is to devote less and less mental space to one’s own intellect, to have less and less faith in one’s own resourcefulness. Jesus is enough.

3:18.2 *To him be the glory both now and into the day of eternity! Amen*: Once again, Jesus Christ is elevated to the highest place, for, with the Father, he is worthy of all praise, presently and eternally. The true Church—stable by Jesus’ grace and in the knowledge of him—has ever and will ever echo this beautiful refrain.

³² Perhaps this justifies to a certain extent the attention in modern times that Paul’s letters have been given out of proportion to their length.

³³ The believers in Asia Minor listened well to Peter’s exhortations, for half a century later a governor of Pontus and Bithynia could find nothing objectionable in their conduct, except that they worshiped God alone (e.g., Pliny, *Letters* 10.99-97).

Works Cited

Davids, Peter H., *The Letters of 2 Peter and Jude*, Pillar New Testament Commentary, William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, Grand Rapids, MI, 2006.

Du Troit, Andrie, "Vilification as a Pragmatic Device in Early Christian Epistolography," *Biblica* 75, No. 3 (1994), pp403-412, Peeters Publishers.

France, R. T., *The Gospel of Matthew*, New International Commentary on the New Testament, William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, Grand Rapids, MI, 2007.

Green, Gene L., *Jude & 2 Peter*, Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament, Baker Academic, Grand Rapids, MI, 2008.

Harris, Murray J., *Prepositions and Theology in the Greek New Testament*, Zondervan, Grand Rapids, MI, 2012.

Knight, George W. III, *The Pastoral Epistles*, The New International Greek Testament Commentary, William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, Grand Rapids, MI, 1992.

Putnam, Rhyné R., *When Doctrine Divides the People of God: An Evangelical Approach to Theological Diversity*, Crossway, Wheaton, IL, 2020.

Schreiner, Thomas R., *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, New American Commentary 37, B&H Publishing Group, Nashville, TN, 2003.

von Siebenthal, Heinrich, *Ancient Greek Grammar for the Study of the New Testament*, Peter Lang, Oxford, UK, 2019.

Sproul, R. C., *1-2 Peter: An Expositional Commentary*, Ligonier Ministries, Sanford, FL, 2019.

Ware, Timothy, *The Orthodox Church: An Introduction of Eastern Christianity*, Penguin Random House, UK, 2015.